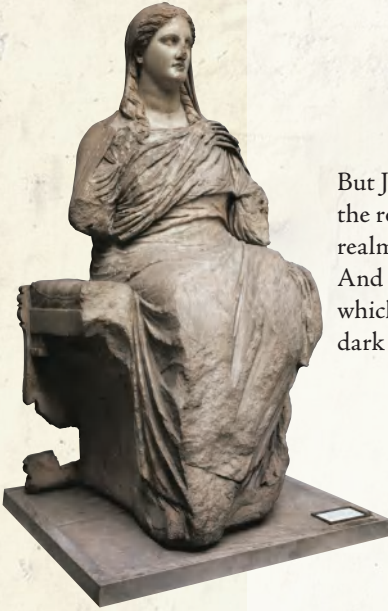




## Demeter and the Eleusinian Mysteries

But Jupiter mediated between his brother and his sorrowful sister and divided the rolling year equally. Now the goddess, her divinity shared between two realms, lives with her mother for as many months as she lives with her husband. And suddenly the cast of her mind and face changed. For now her countenance, which could seem mournful even to Dis, is radiant as the sun, emerging from the dark clouds that had concealed it.

—OVID, *Metamorphoses* 5.564–571

### The Myth of Demeter and Persephone

There are two *Homeric Hymns to Demeter*. Number 13 is a very short prelude.



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I begin to sing about the holy goddess Demeter of the beautiful hair, about her and her very lovely daughter Persephone. Hail, goddess; preserve this city and lead my song.

The lengthy and powerful *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* (2), by contrast, is of the utmost importance; it begins with Hades' abduction of Persephone at the will of Zeus:

I begin to sing about the holy goddess, Demeter of the beautiful hair, about her and her daughter, Persephone of the lovely ankles, whom Hades snatched away; loud-thundering Zeus, who sees all, gave her to him. (1–3)

Alone, away from Demeter of the golden scepter and goodly crops, Persephone was playing with the deep-bosomed daughters of Oceanus and picking flowers along a soft meadow: beautiful roses, crocuses, violets, irises, and hyacinths; and Earth in accordance with the

will of Zeus to please Hades, the host of many, produced as a snare for the fair maiden a wonderful and radiant narcissus, an awesome sight to all, both immortal gods and mortal humans. From its stem a hundred blossoms sprouted forth, and their odor was most sweet. All wide heaven above, the whole earth below, and the swell of the salt sea laughed. The girl was astounded and reached out with both her hands together to pluck the beautiful delight. And the wide-pathed Earth yawned in the Nysaeon plain, and the lord and host of many, who goes by many names, the son of Cronus, rushed at her with his immortal horses. And he snatched her up in his golden chariot and carried her away in tears. (4–20)

She shouted with shrill cries and called on father Zeus, the son of Cronus, the highest and the best, but no one of the immortals or of mortals—not even the olive trees laden with their fruit—heard her voice except for the daughter of Persaeus [Perseus], Hecate, her hair brightly adorned, who listened from her cave as she thought kindly thoughts, and lord Helios, the splendid son of Hyperion. These two heard the maid call on the son of Cronus, father Zeus; but he sat apart, away from the gods, in his temple with its many suppliants, receiving beautiful holy offerings from mortals. By the counsel of Zeus, his brother and her uncle Hades, the son of Cronus, who bears many names, the lord and host of many, led her off with his immortal horses against her will. (20–32)

As long as the goddess could behold the earth, starry heaven, the deep flowing sea full of fish, the rays of the sun, and still hoped to see her dear mother and the race of everlasting gods, hope soothed her great heart, although she was distressed. But the peaks of the mountains and the depths of the sea echoed with her immortal voice, and her lady mother heard her. (33–39)

#### DEMETER'S GRIEF, ANGER, AND RETALIATION

Sharp pain seized Demeter's heart, and she tore the headdress about her ambrosial hair with her own dear hands and threw off the dark covering from both her shoulders; and she rushed in pursuit, just like a bird, over land and water. But no one—either of gods or mortals—wished to tell what had really happened—not even a bird came to her as a messenger of truth. For nine days, then, lady Demeter roamed over the earth holding burning torches in her hands and in her grief did not eat any ambrosia or drink sweet nectar, nor did she bathe her body. But when dawn brought on the light of the tenth day, Hecate, a torch in hand, met her and gave her some news as she exclaimed: "Lady Demeter, bringer of goodly gifts in season, who of the heavenly gods or mortals carried off Persephone and troubled your dear heart? For I heard her voice but did not see with my eyes who it was. I am telling you the whole truth quickly." (40–58)

Thus Hecate spoke, and the daughter of Rhea of the beautiful hair did not answer but swiftly rushed away with her, holding burning torches in her hands. They came to Helios, the lookout for both gods and human beings, and stood before his horses, and the goddess of goddesses spoke: "Helios, do at least have respect for me, a goddess, if I have ever by word or by deed gladdened your heart and your spirits. Through the barren air I heard the piercing cry of the girl whom I bore, a sweet daughter, illustrious in her beauty, as though she were being violated; yet I saw nothing with my eyes. But since you look down from the divine aether with your rays on all the earth and sea, tell me truthfully if you

have seen my dear child at all and who, either of gods or mortals, has seized her alone, away from me, by force against her will and made away.” (59–73)

Thus she spoke. And the son of Hyperion answered her: “Demeter, regal daughter of Rhea of the beautiful hair, you will know the truth. For indeed I revere you greatly and I pity you in your grief for your daughter of the lovely ankles. No other of the immortals is to blame except the cloud-gatherer Zeus, who gave her to his own brother Hades to be called his lovely wife. And he seized her and with his horses carried her away to the gloomy depths below as she cried aloud. But, O goddess, desist from your great lament; you should not thus bear an unrelenting anger to no avail. Indeed Hades, the ruler over many, is not an unseemly husband for your daughter; he is your own brother and born from the same blood; and as for honor, when in the beginning power was divided three ways, his lot was to be made lord of all those with whom he dwelt.” (74–87) 60

Thus he spoke and called out to his horses. And at his cry they nimbly bore the swift chariot, just like long-winged birds. But a more dread and terrible grief possessed Demeter’s heart, and thereafter she was angry with the son of Cronus, Zeus, enwrapped in clouds; she kept away from the gatherings of the gods and high Olympus; and for a long time she went among the cities and rich fields of human beings, disguising her beautiful form. (88–94) 70

#### DEMETER COMES TO ELEUSIS AND THE PALACE OF CELEUS

No one of men or deep-bosomed women who saw her recognized her until she came to the home of wise Celeus, who at that time was ruler of fragrant Eleusis. Grieving in her dear heart, she sat near the road by the Maiden Well, from which the people drew their water; she was in the shade, for an olive tree grew overhead. Her appearance resembled that of a very old woman long past her days for childbearing and the gifts of garland-loving Aphrodite; she was like the nurses for the children of law-pronouncing kings or the housekeepers in their echoing halls. (94–104) 80

The daughters of Celeus, of the family of Eleusis, saw her there as they came after the easily drawn water so that they might bring it in their bronze pitchers to the dear home of their father. There were four of them, just like goddesses in their youthful bloom, Callidice and Cleisidice and lovely Demo and Callithoë, who was the oldest of them all. They did not know Demeter, for it is difficult for mortals to recognize the gods; and standing near they spoke winged words: “Who are you, old woman, of those born long ago? Where are you from? Why have you come away from the city and not approached the houses there, in whose shadowy halls dwell women just like you and younger, who would welcome you in word as well as in deed?” (105–117) 90

Thus they spoke. And she, the queenly goddess, answered with these words: “Dear children, whoever you are of women, I bid you greeting, and I shall tell you my tale. To be sure, it is not inappropriate to relate the truth to you who have asked. My name is Doso, for my lady mother gave it to me. Now then, I have come from Crete over the broad back of the sea—not willingly but against my wishes, for by force pirates carried me away. Then they put in at Thoricus, where the women and the men together disembarked; they were busy with their meal beside the cables of the ship, but my heart had no desire for the delicious food. I hastened away over the black land and escaped from my overbearing masters so that they might not sell me, whom they had not bought, and reap a profit from me. And so I 100



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have come here after my wanderings, and I have no idea at all what land this is or who inhabit it. But may all those who dwell in homes on Olympus grant that you have husbands and bear children just as parents desire. But you maidens pity me now and show concern until, dear children, I come to the home of a man and woman to perform for them zealously the tasks appropriate for an elderly woman like me; I could hold a newborn child in my arms and care for him well, make my master's bed in the recess of his well-built chambers, and teach the women their tasks." (118–144) 110

Thus spoke the goddess, and at once the virgin maiden Calliclida, the most beautiful of the daughters of Celeus, answered: "Good woman, we mortals, even though we suffer, must bear what the gods bestow, for indeed they are much the stronger. I shall help you with the following advice, and I shall tell you the names of the men who have great honor and power here and who are foremost among the people and guard the battlements of our city by their counsels and firm judgments. There is clever Triptolemus and Dioclus and Polyxeinus and noble Eumolpus and Dolichus and our own brave father. All of these have wives who take care of their homes, and no one of them at the very first sight of your person would dishonor you or turn you out of his house, but they will welcome you, for to be sure you are like one of the gods. But if you wish, stay here, so that we may go to our father's house and tell our mother, the deep-bosomed Metaneira, the whole story in the hope that she will bid you come to our place and not search for the homes of the others. She cherishes in our well-built house an only son, born late, a darling long prayed for. If you were to bring him up and he attained the measure of his youth, you would easily be the envy of any woman who saw you. Such are the great rewards that would be yours for your care." (145–168) 130

Thus she spoke, and Demeter nodded her head in agreement. And the girls filled their shining pitchers with water and carried them away happy. Quickly, they came to the great house of their father and told their mother at once what they had seen and heard. She enjoined them to go with all speed and to hire the woman at any price. Just as deer or heifers bound along the meadow when in the springtime they have had their fill of pasture, thus they hurried along the hollow wagon path, holding up the folds of their lovely garments, and their hair, which was like the flower of the crocus, danced about their shoulders. And they found the illustrious goddess where they had left her earlier and thereupon led her to the dear house of their father; she followed behind with her head veiled, distressed at heart, and the dark robe grazed the slender feet of the goddess. (169–183) 140

Soon they arrived at the house of Celeus, a man cherished by Zeus, and passed through the vestibule to where their lady mother sat by the pillar that supported the sturdy roof, holding her son, just a baby, in her lap. Her daughters ran to her, but the goddess stood at the threshold; her head reached up to the beams and she filled the doorway with a divine radiance. Then awe and reverence and fear seized Metaneira, and she sprang up from her couch and bade her guest be seated, but Demeter, the giver of goodly gifts in season, did not wish to sit on the splendid couch but waited in silence with her beautiful eyes downcast, until [the servant] Iambe in her wisdom set out for her a chair, artfully made, and threw a silvery fleece over it; then Demeter sat down, holding her veil over her face with her hands. (184–197) 150



**Demeter.** Marble, second half of the fourth century B.C.; height 58 in. This is the cult statue from the sanctuary of Demeter at Cnidus in Asia Minor. She is shown seated and heavily draped. Her solemn gaze and matronly clothing are consistent with the Demeter of the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)





**Hades and Persephone**, by Gian-Lorenzo Bernini (1598–1680); marble, 1621–1622; height 87 in. Bernini carved this statue for Cardinal Scipione Borghese; it was meant to be seen from the front, for it was placed against a wall. Hades has just seized Persephone and is entering his kingdom, indicated by its guardian, Cerberus, who is seen at the lower right. Persephone twists and cries out as she vainly attempts to escape the clutches of the god. Seen from the right side, the statue is yet more dramatic, for the impression of Hades' fingers sinking into Persephone's thigh and the open jaws of Cerberus (not shown here) heighten the viewer's pity and horror at the violence of the cruel god. (*Scala/Ministero per i Beni e le Attività culturali/Art Resource, NY*)

For a long time she remained seated without a sound, grieving; she did not by word or action acknowledge anyone; but without a smile, not touching food or drink, she sat wasted with longing for her deep-bosomed daughter, until Iambe in her wisdom resorted to many jests and jokes and brought the holy lady around to smile and laugh and bear a happy heart (thereafter, too, Iambe was to cheer her in her anguish). And Metaneira filled a cup with wine as sweet as honey and offered it, but she refused saying that it was not right for her to drink red wine. But she ordered them to mix meal and water with tender mint and give it to her to drink. Metaneira mixed the potion and gave it to the goddess as she had ordered. And the great lady Demeter took it for the sake of the holy rite.<sup>1</sup> (198–211)

160

#### DEMETER NURSES DEMOPHOÖN

Beautifully robed Metaneira was the first to speak among them: "Greetings, O lady, I expect that you are not born of base parents but of noble ones. Majesty and grace shine clearly in your eyes as though from the eyes of royalty who mete out justice. But we mortals, even though we suffer, must bear what the gods bestow, for the yoke lies on our necks. Yet now since you have come here, as much as I have will be yours. Nurse this child, whom the immortals gave me late in life, fulfilling my desperate hopes and endless prayers. If you were to bring him up and he attained the measure of his youth, you would easily be the envy of any woman who saw you. Such are the great rewards that would be yours for your care." Then Demeter of the beautiful crown replied to her: "Sincere greetings to you, also, O lady, and may the gods afford you only good. I shall take the boy gladly, as you bid, and tend to him, and I have good hopes that he will

170

not be harmed or destroyed by any evil charms, for I know much more potent remedies and effective antidotes for harmful spells." (212–230)

Thus she spoke, and with her immortal hands she took the child to her fragrant bosom. And his mother rejoiced in her heart. Thus she nursed in the house the splendid son of wise Celeus, Demophoön, whom beautifully robed Metaneira bore. And he grew like a god, not nourished on mortal food but anointed by Demeter with ambrosia, just as though sprung from the gods, and she breathed sweetness upon him as she held him to her bosom. At night she would hide him in the might of the fire, like a brand, without the knowledge of his dear parents. It was a source of great wonder to them that he grew and flourished before his time, for he was like the gods to look upon. And she would have made him immortal and never to grow old if beautifully robed Metaneira in her foolishness had not seen what was happening, as she watched in the night from her fragrant chamber. Great was her dismay, and she gave a shriek and struck both her thighs, terrified for her child. Amid her groans she uttered winged words: "Demophoön, my child, this stranger buries you within the blazing fire to my anguish and grievous pain." (231–249)

180

190

Thus she spoke in agony, and the goddess of goddesses, Demeter of the beautiful crown, grew angry as she listened; with her immortal hands she snatched from the fire the dear son whom Metaneira had borne in her house, blessing beyond hope, and threw him down on the floor. Demeter was dreadfully angry in her heart as she spoke to beautifully robed Metaneira: "Mortals are ignorant and



**Pluto and Proserpina by Jeff Koons;** stainless steel brushed with yellow-gold paint; decorated with live flowering plants; height 129 in. Koons based his design on an eighteenth-century porcelain figurine. Using twentieth-century materials on a huge scale and twisting them to focus on the violence and speed of Pluto's (Hades') seizure of Proserpina (Persephone), he illuminates the mythical figures by the skillful use of gold color. (©Jeff Koons 2010–2013)

stupid who cannot foresee the fate both good and bad that is in store. Thus you  
 in your foolishness have done a thing that cannot be remedied. I call to witness 200  
 by the relentless waters of the river Styx, the oath of the gods, that I would have  
 made your dear child immortal and never to grow old all his days, and I would  
 have granted him imperishable honor; but now, as it is, he will not be able to  
 escape death and the Fates. Yet imperishable honor will always be his because he  
 has lain on my knees and slept in my arms. But when the years go by and he has  
 reached his prime, the new generation of Eleusinians will continually engage in  
 dread wars and battles all their days. I am Demeter, esteemed and honored as the  
 greatest benefit and joy to mortals and immortals. Now then, let all the people  
 build to me a great temple and an altar with it, below the town and its steep wall,

on the rising hill above the well, Kallichoron. And I myself shall teach my rites, so that performing them with reverence you may propitiate my heart.” (250–274) 210

Thus the goddess spoke and cast aside her old age, transforming her size and appearance. Beauty breathed around and about her, and a delicious odor was wafted from her fragrant garments. The radiance from the immortal person of the goddess shone far and wide, and her golden hair flowed down on her shoulders. The sturdy house was filled with her brilliance as though with a lightning flash. She disappeared from the room, and at once Metaneira’s knees gave way; for a long time she was speechless and did not even remember at all to pick up her late-born son from the floor. But his sisters heard his pitiful cries and sprang down from their beds, spread well with covers; one of them then picked up the child in her arms and took him to her bosom, another stirred the fire, and a third hastened on her delicate feet to rouse their mother from her fragrant chamber. They gathered around the frantic child and bathed him with loving care. But his spirits were not soothed, for the nurses who tended him now were indeed inferior. (275–291) 220

The whole night long, trembling with fear, they made their supplication to the illustrious goddess, and as soon as dawn appeared they told the truth to Celeus, whose power was great, just as Demeter the goddess of the beautiful crown had commanded. Then Celeus called the many people to an assembly and bade them build a splendid temple to Demeter of the lovely hair and an altar on the rising hill. They listened to him as he spoke and immediately complied and did as they were told. And the child flourished by divine destiny. (292–300) 230

#### HADES AND PERSEPHONE AND HER EATING OF THE POMEGRANATE

When they had finished and ceased from their labor, each made his way homeward. But golden Demeter remained sitting there quite apart from all the blessed gods, wasted with longing for her deep-bosomed daughter. And she caused human beings a most terrible and devastating year on the fruitful land. The earth would not send up a single sprout, for Demeter of the lovely crown kept the seed covered. In vain the oxen dragged the many curved ploughs through the fields, and much white barley was sown in the earth to no avail. Now she would have destroyed the entire human race by cruel famine and deprived those who have their homes on Olympus of their glorious prestige from their gifts and sacrifices, if Zeus had not noticed and taken thought in his heart. First, he roused golden-winged Iris to summon Demeter of the lovely hair, desirable in her beauty. (301–315) 240

Thus he ordered. And Iris obeyed Zeus, the dark-clouded son of Cronus, and on swift feet traversed the interval between. She came to the citadel of fragrant Eleusis and found dark-robed Demeter in her temple. She spoke to her, uttering winged words: “Demeter, father Zeus, whose knowledge is imperishable, commands you to join the company of the eternal gods. Come now, let not the word I bring from Zeus be unaccomplished.” (316–323) 250

Thus she spoke in supplication, but Demeter’s heart was unswayed. Thereupon father Zeus sent down to her all the blessed gods who exist forever; and they came one by one, calling out her name and offering her many very beautiful gifts and whatever honors she would like to choose for herself among the immortals. But no one was able to sway her mind and her heart from her anger, and she stubbornly rejected all appeals. She maintained that she would never



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set foot on fragrant Olympus or allow fruit to sprout from the earth until she saw with her own eyes her lovely daughter. (324–333)

Then loud-thundering Zeus, who sees all, sent the slayer of Argus, Hermes, with his golden wand to Erebus to appeal to Hades with gentle words and bring chaste Persephone up from the murky depths to the light, so that her mother might desist from anger when she saw her daughter with her own eyes. Hermes did not disobey, and straightway he left the realms of Olympus and swiftly rushed down to the depths of the earth. He encountered the lord Hades within his house, sitting on a couch with his modest wife, who was very reluctant because of her longing for her mother. And Demeter, far away, brooded over her designs to thwart the actions of the blessed gods. (334–345)

The mighty slayer of Argus stood near and said: “Hades of the dark hair, ruler of the dead, father Zeus has ordered me to bring to him from Erebus august Persephone, so that her mother may see her with her own eyes and desist from her wrath and dread anger against the immortals. For she is devising a great scheme to destroy the feeble tribes of earthborn men by keeping the seed hidden under earth and ruining the honors that are bestowed on the immortals. She clings to her dire wrath and does not associate with the gods but remains on the rocky citadel of Eleusis sitting apart within her fragrant temple.” (346–357)

Thus he spoke. And Hades, the lord of those below, smiled with furrowed brows and did not disobey the commands of Zeus the king; and he hastily ordered wise Persephone: “Go, Persephone, to the side of your dark-robed mother, with a gentle and loving heart in your breast. Be not distraught. I among the immortals shall not be an unworthy husband for you, since I am the full brother of your father, Zeus. While you are here with me you will rule over all that lives and moves, and you will hold the greatest honors among the immortals. Those who wrong you and do not propitiate your power by performing holy rites and sacrifices and offering appropriate gifts will find eternal retribution.” (357–369)

Thus he spoke. And wise Persephone was delighted and jumped up quickly in her joy. But her husband secretly gave her the honey-sweet fruit of the pomegranate to eat, taking thought for himself that she should not remain all her days above with august, dark-robed Demeter. Hades, host of many, then yoked his immortal horses to the front of his golden chariot, which Persephone mounted; the mighty slayer of Argus, Hermes, took the reins and whip in his hands and drove them up and away from the palace; the pair of horses readily sped along and easily covered their long journey. Neither the sea nor streams of rivers nor grassy glens nor mountaintops impeded the onrush of the immortal horses as they cut through the deep air above them in their course. The charioteer brought them to a halt in front of the fragrant temple where Demeter of the lovely crown waited. (370–385)

#### DEMETER'S ECSTATIC REUNION WITH PERSEPHONE

At the sight of her daughter, she rushed out like a maenad down a mountain thick with woods. When Persephone on the other side saw the beautiful eyes of her mother, she leaped down from the chariot with its horses and ran, throwing her arms about her neck in an embrace. But while Demeter still had her dear child in her arms, suddenly her heart sensed some treachery; trembling with dread she let go her loving embrace and asked quickly: “My child, have you eaten any food while you were below? Speak up, do not hide anything so



that we both may know. If you have not, even though you have been in the company of loathsome Hades, you will live with me and your father, Zeus the cloud-gatherer, son of Cronus, in honor among all the immortals. But if you have eaten anything, you will return again beneath the depths of the earth and live there a third part of each year; the other two-thirds of the time you will spend with me and the other immortals. When the spring blooms with all sorts of sweet-smelling flowers, then again you will rise from the gloomy region below, a great wonder for gods and mortals. But tell me, too, by what trick the strong host of many deceived you?" (385–404) 310

The very beautiful Persephone then said in answer: "To be sure, mother, I shall tell you the whole truth. When Hermes, the bringer of luck and swift messenger, came from my father, the son of Cronus, and the other gods of the sky, saying that I was to come up from Erebus in order that you might see me with your own eyes and desist from your wrath and dread anger against the immortals, I immediately jumped up in my joy. But Hades swiftly put in my mouth the fruit of the pomegranate, a honey-sweet morsel, and compelled me to eat it by force against my will. I shall tell you too how he came and carried me down to the depths of the earth through the shrewd plan of my father, the son of Cronus, going through it all as you ask. (405–416) 320

"We were all playing in a lovely meadow: Leucippe, Phaeno, Electra, Ianthé, Melite, Iache, Rhodeia, Callirhoë, Melobosis, Tyche, Ocyrhoë beautiful as a flower, Chryseïs, Ianeira, Acaste, Admete, Rhodope, Pluto, lovely Calypso, Styx and Urania, charming Galaxaura,<sup>2</sup> and Pallas the battle-rouser and Artemis delighting in arrows. (417–424)

"We were playing and gathering lovely flowers in our hands, a mixed array of soft crocuses, irises, hyacinths, roses in full bloom, and lilies, wonderful to behold, and a narcissus, which the wide earth produced, in color yellow of a crocus. I plucked it joyously, but the earth beneath opened wide and thereupon the mighty lord, the host of many, leaped up and carried me away in his golden chariot beneath the earth despite my violent protests—my cries were loud and shrill. I tell you the whole truth, although the story gives me pain." (425–433) 330

Thus they then in mutual love and tender embraces greatly cheered each other's heart and soul the whole long day. Their grief was assuaged as they exchanged their joys. Hecate, her hair brilliantly arrayed, approached them and frequently embraced the holy daughter of Demeter. From that time on, regal Hecate became the lady and attendant of Persephone. (434–440)

#### DEMETER RESTORES FERTILITY AND ESTABLISHES THE MYSTERIES

Loud-thundering Zeus, who sees far and wide, sent as a messenger to them Rhea of the lovely hair to lead dark-robed Demeter among the company of the gods, and he promised to grant her the honors that she would choose among the immortal gods, and he consented that her daughter live a third part of the revolving year in the gloomy depths below and the other two-thirds by the side of her mother and the other immortals. Thus he ordered, and the goddess Rhea did not disobey the message of Zeus. She quickly rushed down from the heights of Olympus and came to the Rharian plain, previously very fertile, but now not fertile at all, standing leafless and barren. The white seed was hidden through the machinations of Demeter of the lovely ankles. But soon thereafter, with the burgeoning of spring, long ears of grain would be luxuriant, and the rich furrows 340 360



Audio



**Hades and Persephone.** Terra-cotta plaque, ca. 460 B.C.; height 10  $\frac{1}{4}$  in. This is one of a series of small votive reliefs from the sanctuary of Persephone at Locri (in southern Italy). The divinities of the Underworld sit enthroned holding emblems connected with their worship—grain, parsley, a cock, a bowl. In front stands a lamp with a tiny cock on it, and another cock stands beneath Persephone's throne. (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)

too along the ground would be laden with grain, some already bound in sheaves. (441–456)

Rhea came from the barren air to this place first of all, and the goddesses beheld each other gladly and rejoiced in their hearts. Rhea, her hair brilliantly arrayed, spoke to Demeter thus: “Come here, my daughter; loud-thundering Zeus, who sees far and wide, summons you to join the company of the gods, and he has promised to grant you whatever honors you would like among the immortals, and he has consented that your daughter live a third part of the revolving year in the gloomy depths below and the other two-thirds with you and the other gods. Thus he said it would be accomplished and nodded his head in assent. But come, my child, and be obedient; do not persist in your relentless anger against Zeus, the dark-clouded son of Cronus. But quickly make grow for human beings the life-bringing fruit in abundance.” (457–469)

Thus she spoke, and Demeter of the lovely crown obeyed. Quickly, she caused fruit to spring up from the fertile plains, and the whole wide land was laden with leaves and flowers. She went to the kings who minister justice (Triptolemus, Diocles, the rider of horses, the mighty Eumolpus, and Celeus, the leader of the people) and showed them the performance of her holy rites and taught her mysteries to them all, Triptolemus and Polyxeinus and Diocles besides—holy mysteries that one may not by any means violate or question or express. For the great reverence due to the gods restrains one's voice.

Happy is the one of mortals on earth who has seen these things. But those who are uninitiated into the holy rites and have no part never are destined to a similar joy when they are dead in the gloomy realm below. (470–482)

But when the goddess of goddesses had ordained all these things, they made their way to Olympus among the company of the other gods. There they dwell beside Zeus, who delights in the thunder, august and holy goddesses. Greatly

happy is the one of mortals on earth whom they dearly love; straightway they send, as a guest to his great house, Plutus, who gives wealth to human beings. (483–489)

390

Come now you who hold power over the land of fragrant Eleusis, sea-girt Paros, and rocky Antron, lady and queen Demeter, the giver of good things in season, both yourself and your daughter, very beautiful Persephone, kindly grant me a pleasing substance in reward for my song. Yet I shall remember both you and another song too. (490–495)

## Interpretations of the Hymn

The myth of Demeter and Persephone represents another variation of a fundamental and recurring theme—the death and rebirth of vegetation as a metaphor or allegory for spiritual resurrection. In the New Testament (John 12:24), this archetype is expressed in this way: “Unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies it bears much fruit.” In this Greek hymn, the allegory is rendered in terms of the touching emotions of mother and daughter; more often the symbols and metaphors involve the relationship between a fertility goddess and her male partner, either lover or son (e.g., Aphrodite and Adonis, Cybele and Attis, Semele and Dionysus). Demeter is often imagined as the goddess of the ripe grain; Persephone then is the deity of the budding tender shoots. They are invoked together as the “two goddesses.” Persephone (who is often called merely *Kore*, a name meaning “girl”) is the daughter of Demeter and Zeus, who enact once again the sacred marriage between earth-goddess and sky-god.

This is a hymn permeated by emotional longings and religious allegories about death and rebirth, resurrection, and salvation. The parable of the infant **Demophoön** is particularly revealing. Nursed and cherished by Demeter, he flourished like a god and would have become immortal, his impure mortality cleansed away in the fire, if only the unfortunate Metaneira, who did not understand the rituals, had not interfered. If we are nourished like this child by Demeter’s truth and become initiated into her mysteries, we too shall find redemption, immortality, and joy through the same love and devotion of this holy mother, lavished not only upon Demophoön but also her lovely daughter.

The *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* also illustrates the grim character of Hades in his method of obtaining a wife and provides the mythological reasons for Hecate’s



**Persephone, Hermes, and Hecate.** Athenian red-figure krater, ca. 440 B.C. Persephone emerges from the Underworld under the protection of Hermes *psychopompos*, who looks directly at the viewer. He is dressed as a traveler and wears the *petasus* and *chlamys* (traveler's cloak), while the caduceus in his left hand points toward the ground. To the right Hecate, looking back at Persephone and with a torch in each hand, lights the way. (Image copyright © The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)

prominence as a goddess of the Underworld. Hades' basic character as a fertility god is evident from the location of his realm, the violence of his nature, and his link with horses. He is thus a god of agricultural wealth (compare his names, Pluto or Dis, among the Romans); but he should not be confused with Plutus (Wealth) mentioned in the last lines of the hymn, another deity of agricultural plenty and prosperity (and thus wealth in general), the offspring of Demeter and Iasion.



## Triptolemus

Triptolemus, who also appears in the concluding lines of the hymn, is generally depicted as the messenger of Demeter when she restored fertility to the ground. He is the one who taught and spread her arts of agriculture to new lands at that time and later, often traveling in a magical car drawn by winged dragons, a gift of Demeter. He is sometimes either merged in identity with the infant Demophoön (variant spelling is Demophon) of the hymn or said to be his brother; in Plato, Triptolemus is a judge of the dead.

## The Eleusinian Mysteries

This hymn to Demeter is of major importance because it provides the most significant evidence that we have for the nature of the worship of Demeter at **Eleusis**. The town of Eleusis is about 14 miles west of Athens; the religion and ceremony that developed in honor of Demeter and her daughter had its center here, but the city of Athens, too, was intimately involved. This religious observance was of a special kind, not the general prerogative of everyone but open only to those who wished to become initiates. These devotees were sworn to absolute secrecy and faced dire punishments if they revealed the secret rites.<sup>3</sup> This does not imply that initiation was confined to a select few. In early times, membership was inevitably limited to the people of Eleusis and Athens; but soon participants came from all areas of the Hellenic world and eventually from the Roman Empire as well.

This worship of Demeter was not restricted to men; women, children, and even slaves could participate. Appropriately, the religious celebration that evolved was given the name of the Eleusinian mysteries. Demeter, then, along with other Hellenic deities, is the inspiration for a kind of worship that is generally designated as the mystery religions (compare elements in the worship of Dionysus and aspects of the devotion to Aphrodite and Adonis or Cybele and Attis). Orpheus is credited with originating the mysteries, and the nature of Orphism and kindred mystery religions will be considered in Chapter 16. Although there must have been differences among the various mystery religions (some of them probably quite marked) obvious to the ancient world, today we have difficulty distinguishing precisely among them. It seems certain that the major common denominator is a belief in the immortality of the soul and a future life.

**The Departure of Triptolemus.** Attic red-figure cup by Makron, ca. 480 B.C.; height 8 ¼ in. Triptolemus holds stalks of grain in his left hand and in his right hand a dish (*phiale*), into which Persephone pours liquid from the jug in her right hand: she holds a torch in her left hand. The libation is a necessary ritual before departure on a journey. To the left stands Demeter, holding a torch and grain-stalks, and the personification of Eleusis stands behind Persephone. Triptolemus sits in a throne-like wheeled vehicle, whose wings symbolize the speed and extent of his travels, while the serpent indicates his association with the grain-bearing earth. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)



The mysteries at Eleusis were kept secret so successfully that scholars are by no means agreed about what can be said with any certainty, particularly about the highest and most profound elements of the worship. The sanctuary at Eleusis has been excavated,<sup>4</sup> and buildings connected with the ceremonies have been found; most important among them is the temple of Demeter, where the final revelation of the mysteries was celebrated.<sup>5</sup> But no evidence has been unearthed that might dispel the secrecy with absolute certainty once and for all. The priests in charge of the rites presumably transmitted orally what Demeter was said to have taught.

It is impossible to know just how much of the ritual is revealed in the *Hymn to Demeter*. It would be presumptuous to imagine that the most profound secrets are here for all to read, and we cannot be sure how much may be inferred from what is directly stated. That elements of the ceremonies are indicated cannot be denied, but presumably these are only the elements that were witnessed or revealed to all, not only to the initiated. Thus the text prescribes such details as an interval of nine days, fasting, the carrying of torches, the exchange of jests, the partaking of the drink **Kykeon**, the wearing of a special dress (e.g., the veil of Demeter); even precise geographical indications (e.g., the Maiden Well and the site of the temple) are designated.

The emotional tone of the poem, too, might hold the key for a mystic performance in connection with the celebrations. The anguish of Demeter, her frantic wanderings and search, the traumatic episode with Demophoön, the miraculous transformation of the goddess, the thrilling reunion between mother and daughter, the blessed return of vegetation to a barren earth—these are some of the obvious emotional and dramatic highlights.

## The Greater and Lesser Mysteries

On the basis of our inadequate evidence, we present the following tentative outline of basic procedures in the celebration of the Eleusinian mysteries; ultimate revelation and meaning are matters of more tenuous conjecture. Two major compulsory stages had to be undertaken: (1) participation in the Lesser Mysteries, involving preliminary steps in initiation; (2) advancement to the Greater Mysteries, which entailed full initiation into the cult. A third stage, not required but possible, entailed participation in the highest rites.<sup>6</sup> It is immediately apparent that these mysteries are basically different from the festivals celebrated in the Panhellenic sanctuaries at Olympia and Delphi, which were open to all, without secrecy or initiation or a fundamental mystic philosophy, however religious the tone that oracular response and devotion to a god might set.

Two major priestly families were connected with Eleusis.<sup>7</sup> Among the many important priesthoods and assistant officials, the highest was that of the **Hierophant**. This priest alone could reveal to the worshipers the ultimate mysteries that entailed the showing of the **Hiera**, the sacred objects—his title means “he who reveals the Hiera.” Prominent too was the priestess of Demeter, who lived in a sacred house. Many of the priests received a fixed sum of money from each initiate as a fee for their services. The initiate was sponsored and directed by a patron.<sup>8</sup>

The Lesser Mysteries were held in Athens, usually once a year in early spring. Precise details are unknown, but the general purpose was certainly the preliminary preparation of the initiates for subsequent advancement to higher things.

Ceremonies probably focused on ritual purification, involving sacrifices, prayer, fasting, and cleansing by water.

The Greater Mysteries were held annually during the months of September and October. A holy truce was declared for a period of fifty-five days, and heralds were sent to issue invitations to states. Both Athens and Eleusis were involved in the festivities. Preliminary to the festival proper was the day on which the *Hiera* were taken out of the temple of Demeter in Eleusis and brought to Athens amid great pomp and ceremony. The splendid procession, headed by the priests and priestesses who carried the *Hiera* in sacred caskets bound by ribbons, was met officially in Athens and escorted in state to the sanctuary of Demeter in the city (the Eleusinion). The next day began the formal celebration of the Greater Mysteries, which continued through eight days, the ceremonies culminating in Eleusis, with a return to Athens on the ninth. The first day saw the people summoned to an assembly in the Athenian agora; those who were pure and knew Greek were invited by proclamation to participate in the mysteries. On the second day, all participants were ordered to cleanse themselves in the sea. The third day was devoted to sacrifices and prayers. The fourth day was spent honoring the god of healing, Asclepius, who according to tradition had in previous times arrived late for initiation. So on this day other latecomers could enroll.

The festivities in Athens culminated on the fifth day in a brilliant procession back to Eleusis. Priests and laymen wended their prescribed way, crowned with myrtle and carrying mystic branches of myrtle tied with wool strands.<sup>9</sup> Heading the procession was a wooden statue of Iacchus (very likely another name for the god Dionysus) escorted in a carriage. At some stages of the journey, abuse, jest, and insults in scurrilous language were exchanged, perhaps in part to instill humility in the throng. Prayers were chanted and hymns sung; torches were carried and lit as night fell, and the sacred procession reached the sanctuary of Demeter in Eleusis.

The sixth and seventh days brought the initiates to the secret core of the mysteries, and it seems safe to assume that much of the ritual was performed in remembrance of the episodes described in the *Hymn to Demeter*. Thus there was a fast (certain foods, such as pomegranates and beans, were prohibited) and a vigil; the fast was probably ended by the drinking of the prescribed drink, the *Kykeon*, whatever its significance.

## Conjectures about the Revelation

The heart of the ceremonies, which were celebrated in Demeter's temple, apparently involved three stages: a dramatic enactment, the revelation of sacred objects, and the uttering of certain words. What were the themes of the dramatic pageant? Probably it focused on incidents from the story of Demeter and her wanderings and other episodes recorded in the hymn, all designed to elicit a religious catharsis. Some have suggested scenes of an Orphic character involving a simulated trip to the Underworld, with fabricated apparitions of terror and sublimity as the action moved from Hell (Tartarus) to Paradise (Elysium). That no underground chambers have been found in the excavations does not necessarily invalidate this theory. We do not know whether the initiates merely witnessed the drama or actually participated in it. Eventually, the culmination was the awe-inspiring exhibition by the Hierophant himself of the holy objects, bathed in a

## The Niinnion Pinax and the Celebration of the Mysteries at Eleusis

This clay tablet is a *pinax* (a votive plaque set up in a sanctuary to honor a god or goddess). This particular pinax has the name of the woman who dedicated it, Niinnion, inscribed along the bottom, and indicates that it was dedicated to “the two goddesses,” Demeter and Persephone. It is in the shape of a temple with a pediment. It was discovered, broken into nine pieces, at Eleusis in 1895. It is now in the National Archaeological Museum in Athens.

There are many questions about what this plaque is intended to illustrate: does it represent the celebration of the mysteries or another festival associated with Attica and Eleusis? Who precisely are the individual figures, and what are the other objects in the scene? Does it represent one single, discrete incident in a ritual, or is it a composite? Although absolute certainty is elusive, the plaque remains a provocative and compelling reminder of how difficult it can be to interpret a work that is so highly allusive and suggestive.

The great majority of scholars interpret the plaque as representing scenes associated with the mysteries. The column in the upper left corner may indicate

**Niinnion Pinax.** Red-figure clay votive tablet, ca. 370 B.C.; height: 0.44 m.; width: 0.32 m. (akg/De Agostini Picture Library)



Closer Look





that we are within a sanctuary. A thin, white line curls through the center of the plaque and might indicate that the figures are to be understood as representing two groups. Perhaps the scene is depicting two processions, with the one in the upper part of the panel being the procession during the celebration of the Greater Mysteries and the one in the lower part of the panel being the procession of the Lesser Mysteries.

The lower scene, starting from the left, shows a mature, bearded male, crowned in myrtle and carrying over his shoulder a staff, which has a pouch tied to it. A woman precedes him, holding a staff with a pouch in one hand and a sprig of myrtle in the other. Myrtle had sacred associations in the rites of both Demeter and Dionysus. The gesture she makes signifies an attitude of reverence or adoration. This woman has been identified by some as Niinnion herself, taking part in the procession from Athens to Eleusis in preparation for the celebration of the Greater Mysteries proper. Upon her head she is carrying a *kernos* (a sacred vessel for offerings), which was used in the rites of Eleusis. The *Kernophoria* (Bearing of the Kerno) was indeed part of the Greater and Lesser Mysteries. She stands on her toes and appears to be dancing. In front of her stands a figure, whose size seems to indicate that he is not a mortal but a god. He, too, wears a myrtle wreath upon his head and is leading the two *mystai* (initiates). He carries two torches, one pointed up and the other down. This may suggest the divergent existence of Persephone in the upper and lower worlds. This figure has been identified as Iacchus, an avatar of Dionysus, who is associated with the Mysteries of Eleusis. During the procession to Eleusis, preceded by a statue of Iacchus, the initiates would utter the cry "Iacche! Iacche!" signaling their excitement and anticipation. The figures in the lower panel make their procession to a seated goddess, who has been identified as Demeter. She is holding a *phiale* (libation vessel) and a staff. Between Iacchus and Demeter are depicted objects associated with Eleusis. The two crossing rods may be *bacchoi*, the sacred wands carried in the torch-lit procession to Eleusis. The white semicircular object is a bit harder to explain. Scholars have variously interpreted it: an *omphalos* (navel-stone); the rock left exposed within the *anaktoron* (the enclosed structure within the Telesterion); the *pelanos* (sacred cake offering of barley and wheat); or perhaps the *kiste* (covered basket), symbolizing the secrecy at the heart of the ritual.

In the upper register, from the left, we see a bearded male, crowned with a myrtle wreath and holding two sprigs of myrtle (the same man as below?); a garlanded youth who holds a cup in one hand and a staff in the other; and another woman bearing a *kernos* on her head. This woman has also been identified as Niinnion, depicted at a different moment in the ritual. A much larger figure, a goddess, precedes her, bearing torches, both of which point upward. Some have taken her to be Persephone leading the initiates toward her mother, Demeter, who is seated and holding a scepter. Others have understood the torch-bearing woman to be Hecate, who would certainly not be out of place in the scene. The coloring of the seated goddess is problematic. All the other female figures, whether mortal or divine, are depicted in white. Might she be Persephone, darkened to represent her chthonic existence?

The triangular pediment depicts the *Pannychis*, the nighttime celebration that followed the arrival of the initiates in Eleusis.



radiant light as he delivered his mystic utterances. The highest stage of all, which was not required for full initiation, entailed further revelation of some sort. The eighth day concluded the ceremonies; the ninth brought the return to Athens, this time with no organized procession. The following day the Athenian council heard a full report on the conduct of the ceremonies.

Conjectures about the exact nature of the highest mysteries have been legion. Comments by the fathers of the Christian church have been brought to witness, but their testimony has been rightly viewed with grave suspicion because it was probably rooted in prejudice, stemming from ignorance and hostility. No one of them had ever been initiated into the mysteries, and surprisingly enough, those Christian converts who had been initiated seem to have continued to take their pledges of secrecy very seriously. It has been claimed that the ultimate revelation was connected with the transformation of the Eleusinian plain into a field of golden grain (as in the hymn). The heart of the mysteries consisted of no more than showing an ear of grain to the worshipers. Thus we actually *do* know the secrets; or, if you like, they are really not worth knowing at all in terms of serious religious thought. Yet this ear of grain may, after all, realistically and allegorically represent the enigma of the mystery itself. Others insist on an enactment of the holy marriage in connection with the ceremonies, imagining not a spiritual but a literal sexual union between the Hierophant and the Priestess of Demeter. The Hieria too might be a representation of the female genitalia and, since Dionysus may be linked with Demeter and Kore, the male phallus as well. These holy objects were witnessed, or even manipulated, by the initiates in the course of the ritual. But there is no good evidence to argue with any certainty for such orgiastic procedures. The Hieria, as has been conjectured, could have been merely sacred and antique relics handed down from the Mycenaean Age.

It is difficult to agree with those who assert that Dionysus was completely excluded from the worship of Demeter at Eleusis. Iacchus has good claims to be

## The Festival of the Thesmophoria

Women generally played a dominant role in the religion of the ancient world. Only women were permitted to participate in the celebration of some of these rites, and not only men but also virgins and children were excluded. One of the most famous of these women's festivals was the Thesmophoria, common to all Greece. The rites as performed in Athens became the subject of Aristophanes' comedy *Thesmophoriazusae*, which focused on the doings of the feminine participants and the dire consequences for any male who dared to intrude. The festival, lasting five days, took place in the fall, and its purpose was to ensure fertility, especially that of the crops to be sowed. Important in the ceremonies was the throwing of piglets into subterranean pits; after three days, their remains were recovered and mixed with the seed to be planted in hopes of a good harvest. The etiology for this practice was provided by the myth of Eubouleus, a swineherd, who was swallowed up with his swine by the earth at the very time Persephone was taken by Pluto. Celebrations also included sexual abstinence, a procession, sacrifices, fasting and feasting, and even ribald jests.<sup>10</sup>

Dionysus. And the myth of Zagreus-Dionysus, which provides the authority for Orphism (see pp. 322 and 390), makes Persephone his mother. Any spiritual message in the cult at Eleusis must have, in common with Dionysiac cults, a belief in the immortality of the soul and in redemption. If a doctrine similar to that of Orphism is also involved, it need not spring directly from Orphism. The confusion arises because all the mystery religions (whatever their precise interrelation)<sup>11</sup> did in fact preach certain things in common.

The death and rebirth of vegetation as deified in Demeter and Kore surely suggest a belief in the afterlife. After all, this is the promise of the hymn: "But the one who is not initiated into the holy rites and has no part never is destined to a similar joy when he is dead in the gloomy realm below." If at some future time, only obscure evidence remained for the ritual of the Christian Mass, scholars might imagine all sorts of things and miss completely the religious and spiritual doctrine on which it rests. The words uttered by the Hierophant could have ordained spiritual direction and hope. But there was no church body as such for the followers of Demeter, in the sense that they were required to return each year; we know of no sacred writings like those, say, of Orphism. George Mylonas' conclusions affirm the universal power of the matriarchal cult of Demeter in the Graeco-Roman world:

*Whatever the substance and meaning of the Mysteries was, the fact remains that the cult of Eleusis satisfied the most sincere yearnings and the deepest longings of the human heart. The initiates returned from their pilgrimage to Eleusis full of joy and happiness, with the fear of death diminished and the strengthened hope of a better life in the world of shadows: "Thrice happy are those of mortals, who having seen those rites depart for Hades; for to them alone is it granted to have true life there; to the rest all there is evil," Sophocles cries out exultantly. And to this Pindar with equal exultation answers: "Happy is he who, having seen these rites goes below the hollow earth; for he knows the end of life and he knows its god-sent beginning." When we read these and other similar statements written by the great or nearly great of the ancient world, by the dramatists and the thinkers, when we picture the magnificent buildings and monuments constructed at Eleusis by great political figures like Peisistratos, Kimon, Perikles, Hadrian, Marcus Aurelius and others, we cannot help but believe that the Mysteries of Eleusis were not an empty, childish affair devised by shrewd priests to fool the peasant and the ignorant, but a philosophy of life that possessed substance and meaning and imparted a modicum of truth to the yearning human soul. That belief is strengthened when we read in Cicero that Athens has given nothing to the world more excellent or divine than the Eleusinian Mysteries. Let us recall again that the rites of Eleusis were held for some two thousand years; that for two thousand years civilized humanity was sustained and ennobled by those rites. Then we shall be able to appreciate the meaning and importance of Eleusis and of the cult of Demeter in the pre-Christian era. When Christianity conquered the Mediterranean world, the rites of Demeter, having perhaps fulfilled their mission to humanity, came to an end. The "bubbling spring" of hope and inspiration that once existed by the Kallichoron well became dry and the world turned to other living sources for sustenance. The cult that inspired the world for so long was gradually forgotten, and its secrets were buried with its last Hierophant.<sup>12</sup>*

Finally, a word of caution about the usual generalizations put forth concerning the dichotomy between the mystery religions and the state religions (see pp. 154–155) of antiquity. The argument runs something like this. The formal

state religions were sterile or very soon became so; people's hope and faith lay only in the vivid experience offered by the mysteries. Whatever the general truth of this view, it must be noted that for classical Greece, at any rate, the lines are not so distinct. Ceremonies connected with Demeter at Eleusis are tied securely to the policies of the Athenian state. The *archon basileus* (an Athenian official in charge of religious matters in general) directed the celebrations for Demeter in Athens. The Athenian council as a political body was very much concerned about the festival. The pomp and procession involved are startlingly similar to the pageant connected with the Panathenaic festival in honor of Athena, a civic function, whatever its spiritual import. The "church" at Eleusis and the Athenian state were, to all intents and purposes, one.

## The Triumph of Matriarchy

Again and again there appear in mythology variations on the theme of the dominant earth-goddess and her subordinate male lover, who dies and is reborn to ensure the resurrection of the crops and of the souls of mortals. Demeter's name may mean "earth mother," but her myth and that of Persephone introduce a startling and drastic variation of this eternal and universal archetype. The myth's blatant sexuality is replaced by a more refined and purer concept of motherhood and the love between a mother and daughter. In this guise, with nobility and humanity, the mother-goddess and matriarchy sustained their dominance in the ancient world.

Details of the myth continually challenge Zeus' patriarchal power. The abduction of Persephone ordained by the supreme god so that Hades might have a wife and the Underworld might have a queen is depicted not as a divine right but a brutal rape, seen from the point of view of Demeter, who will not accept the status quo and is mighty enough to modify it. Through compromise, both the will of Zeus and the will of Demeter are fulfilled. Demeter shares the love and the person of her daughter with Hades; Hades has his wife; and Persephone attains honor as queen of the Underworld: the mystic cycle of death and rebirth is explained by a myth accommodating a specific matriarchal religious ritual, promising joy in this life and the next.

As we have seen, the Eleusinian mysteries were an inspiring spiritual force and became the one universal mystery religion of the ancient world before Christianity. Indeed, matriarchy was very much alive and well in the patriarchal world of the Greeks and the Romans.

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| Homeric Hymn 2  | <i>To Demeter</i> |
| Homeric Hymn 13 | <i>To Demeter</i> |

### Additional Sources

|              |                                                                                     |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Aristophanes | <i>Thesmophoriazuse</i>                                                             |
| Herodotus    | <i>History of the Persian Wars</i> 8.65.1–6 (a mysterious cloud comes from Eleusis) |
| Ovid         | <i>Metamorphoses</i> 5.341–571                                                      |

## Notes

1. That is, “to initiate and observe the holy rite or sacrament.” There appears to be a lacuna after this sentence. The words translated “for the sake of the holy rite” are difficult, and their precise meaning is disputed. The reference must be to an important part of the ceremony of the Eleusinian mysteries, namely, the partaking of a drink called the *Kykeon*. But the nature and significance of the ritual are unknown: was this in any real sense the sharing of a sacrament, an act of communion fraught with mystic significance, or was it merely a token remembrance of these hallowed actions of the goddess?
2. Sixteen of these names are listed among the daughters of Oceanus and Tethys by Hesiod (*Theogony* 346–361); and Melite is a Nereid (246). The poet adds Leucippe, Phaeno, Iache, and Rhodope.
3. The charges against Alcibiades mentioned in the box on p. 292 are indicative of the seriousness of the consequences if the sacred ceremonies were divulged or desecrated in any way.
4. See in particular George E. Mylonas, *Eleusis and the Eleusinian Mysteries* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1961); this remains the best general survey of all the evidence and the inherent archaeological, historical, religious, and philosophical problems. For the priestess of Demeter and Kore at Eleusis, see Joan Breton Connelly, *Portrait of a Priestess* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2007), pp. 64–69.
5. As a place for the celebration of the mysteries (the Greek word is *teletai*), the temple of Demeter is called a *telesterion*.
6. Known as the *Epoptheia*.
7. The Eumolpids (whose ancestor Eumolpus, according to the hymn, received the mysteries from Demeter herself) and the Kerykes.
8. The initiate was the *mystes* and his patron the *mystagogos*.
9. Aristophanes' *Frogs*, 340 ff., gives us some idea of this procession.

10. Another important woman's festival in honor of Demeter, the Haloa, during the season of wine making, celebrated Dionysus as well. There was an abundance of food and drink, and the worshipers were particularly raucous and ribald. See Matthew Dillon, *Girls and Women in Classical Greek Religion* (New York: Routledge, 2002). For a survey of festivals, see H. W. Parke, *Festivals of the Athenians* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1977); also Erika Simon, *Festivals of Attica: An Archaeological Commentary* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1983).
11. Herodotus (8.65) tells a tale about a mysterious cloud (arising from Eleusis amidst the strains of the mystic hymn to Iacchus) that provided a true omen of future events; in the context, the worship of the mother and the maiden is mentioned. This miracle sets the right tone for elements common to the worship and myths of both Demeter and Dionysus. It is not impossible that the passion of this resurrection-god played some role in the mysteries; Dionysus, too, is close to drama, and drama lies at the essence of the emotional aspects of Eleusinian ritual.
12. Mylonas, *Eleusis and the Eleusinian Mysteries*, pp. 284–285; footnotes are omitted.

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to [www.oup.com/us/morford](http://www.oup.com/us/morford).

## Views of the Afterlife: The Realm of Hades

### *An Ancient Painting of the Underworld*

The water appears to be a river, clearly representing Acheron, and there are reeds growing in it and fish. The shapes of the fish are so faintly drawn you would guess they were shadows rather than fish. And on the river there is a boat and at the oars the ferryman.

—PAUSANIAS, *Description of Greece* 10.28.1



### Homer's Book of the Dead

The earliest surviving account of the realm of Hades appears in Book 11 of the *Odyssey*. Homer's geographical and spiritual depiction is fundamental to subsequent elaborations and thus deserves to be excerpted at some length. Odysseus is telling the Phaeacians and their king Alcinöus of his visit to the Underworld, where he must consult the seer Tiresias about how to reach Ithaca, his homeland (12–99):

Our ship came to the farthest realm of deep-flowing Oceanus, where the country of the Cimmerians lies shrouded in cloud and mist. Bright Helios never looks down on them with his rays, either when he ascends to starry heaven or returns to earth; but dire night covers these poor mortals. Here we beached our ship, and after putting the animals ashore, we went along the stream of Oceanus until we came to the place that Circe had indicated. Here two of my men, Perimedes and Eurylochus, held the sacrificial victims, and I drew my sharp sword from my side and dug a pit about 18 inches square. Around it I poured a libation to all the dead, first with a mixture of honey and milk, then with sweet wine, and a third time with water; over this I sprinkled white barley. I then supplicated the many strengthless

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